The 2017 Heights of Winter rogaine was held on a tough course in the Kaituna Valley on Banks Peninsula. The area of land was very small for a 12 hour course, but the many brutal climbs meant that the speed of travel was deceptively slow. The key to a successful route on this course was to minimise the climbing. If you fell into the trap of planning a course that was too long, you were in good company, as there were lots of discussions afterwards about having to shorten the planned route – even from the top teams. As planners, we initially fell into the same trap, but quickly realised that the area was plenty big enough as soon as we started our reconnaissance. Setting out lots of check points helped us to provide you with plenty of options and kept the guns on their toes.

The winners were the current world champion Greig Hamilton and team mate Nick Hann who visited 59 of the 83 checkpoints on offer, scoring 3430 points. That makes it five wins in a row for Greig at the Heights of Winter, with a variety of partners.

World championship silver medallists Emily Forne and Katie Bolt teamed up with Sara Prince to take out the women's grade with 2370 points. But the top woman's score of 2410 points went to Nicki McFadzien, who formed a mixed team with Sam Walton and Hamish Walton.

The six hour event was won by the veteran men's pairing of Alistair Cory-Wright and John Fitch. The junior team of Marisol Hunter and Sophie Glover were the top women's team, but Nicky Armstrong was the top woman, teaming up with Christian Sax in the mixed open grade.

Full results are available on the Results page at rogaine.org.nz. Greig Hamilton produced an analysis of all the routes to help you work out your perfect route after the event. The distances and height gains in Greig's analysis are based on straight line routes, so tend to underestimate the distance and overestimate the height. Greig and Nick actually travelled 63km with 4150m of climbing.

The theme for the event was Time for Trees. Whilst planning the course I was struck by the many beautiful areas of native trees on the course, acting as a reminder of the loss of trees in the Port Hills fires. At every event that the NZRA organises, we try to involve and give something back to the local community. This has traditionally involved catering from local schools, like Tai Tapu who helped this year. This year we have also donated $1,000 to the Summit Road Society (summitroadsociety.org.nz) to help with replanting after the fires. Helping the local community isn't just about giving money. Giving time is just as important and I encourage you to keep a look out to volunteer your time to help replant the Port Hills. We will post information on the rogaine web site and Facebook page. This year's prizes also kept to the Time for Trees theme, with native trees kindly donated by CJs Plant Farm in Amberley (cjsplants.co.nz).